

T-storm 88/75 • Tomorrow: T-storm 89/78 **B20**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, JULY 15, 2025 • \$4

Education Dept. cuts can go on, justices say

Supreme Court allows deep staff reductions as legal battles continue

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL, LAURA MECKLER AND DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL

A divided Supreme Court on Monday cleared the way for the Trump administration to sharply shrink the Education Department, one of the cornerstones of the president's efforts to radically downsize the federal government.

The justices lifted a temporary lower-court ruling that prevented Trump officials from slashing more than a third of the department's more than 4,100 workers and shifting some of its functions to the states and other agencies as litigation over the cuts plays out in the lower courts.

As is common with cases decided on the emergency docket, the majority did not explain its rationale for the decision. Justice Sonia Sotomayor wrote a scathing dissent that was joined by the court's two other liberals, labeling the ruling "indefensible" and a major expansion of presidential power.

"When the Executive publicly announces its intent to break the law, and then executes on that promise, it is the Judiciary's duty to check that lawlessness, not expedite it," Sotomayor wrote.

She added that the court "hands the Executive the power to repeal statutes by firing all those necessary to carry them out. The majority is either willfully blind to the implications of its ruling or

SEE EDUCATION ON A7

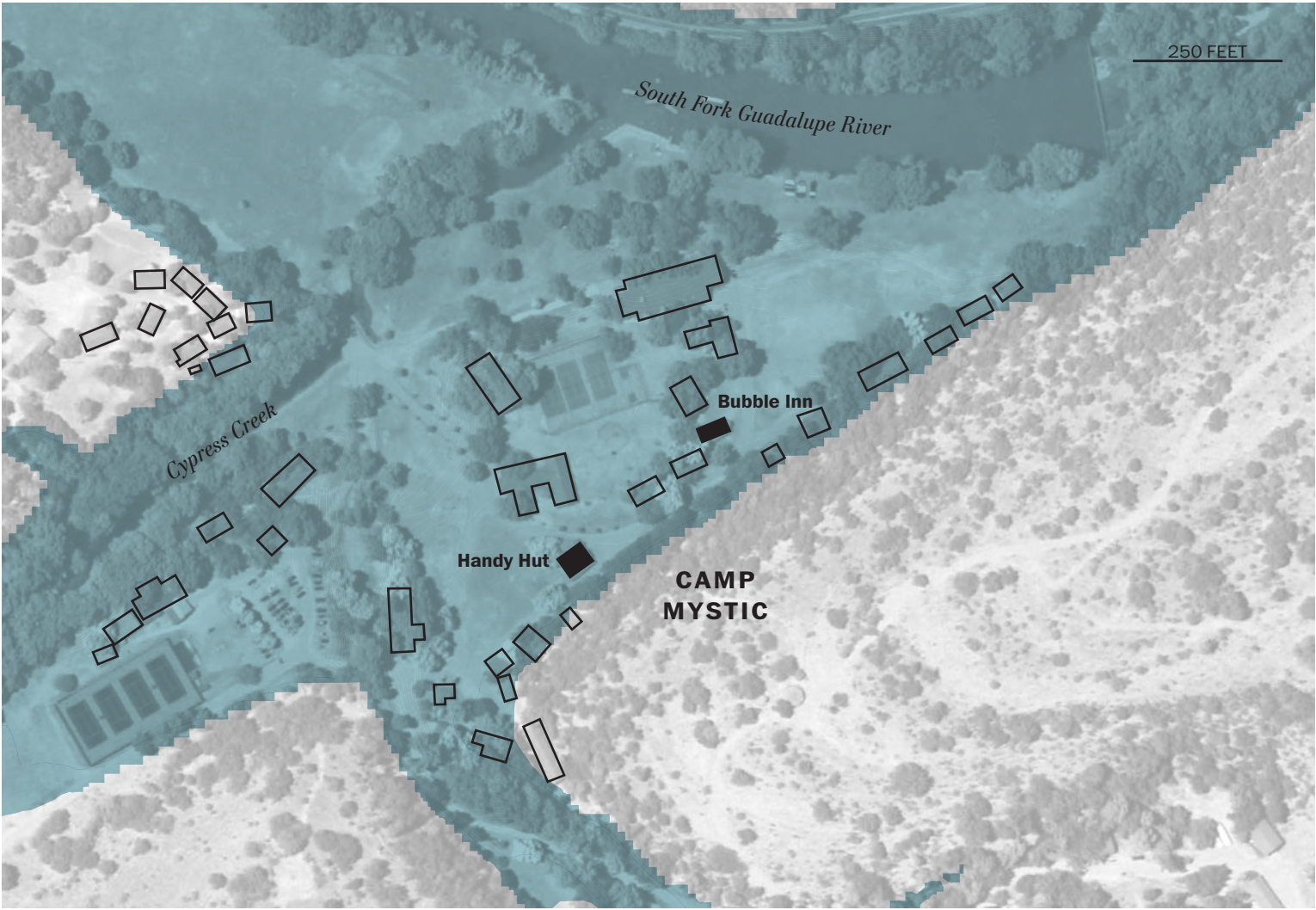
Education cuts: States sue for release of \$7 billion in funding. **A2**

RIF battles: Despite court wins, officials prepare for more fights. **A4**

State Department: China policy staff cut in major overhaul. **A13**

Extent of flooding at Camp Mystic

Water levels rose to at least four feet around many of the cabins.



Source: ICEYE

Leaders evacuated camp an hour after alert

This article is by Annie Gowen, John Muyskens, Arelis R. Hernández, Daniel Wolfe, Nicole Dungea, Naema Ahmed, Todd C. Frankel and Kevin Crowe

Camp Mystic Executive Director Richard "Dick" Eastland did not begin to evacuate the young campers asleep in cabins near the rapidly rising Guadalupe River for more than an hour after he received a severe flood warning on his phone from the National Weather Service at 1:14 a.m. on July 4, the family said through a spokesman.

Eastland — who had run the beloved Christian-centered all-girls camp in Hunt, Texas, with his wife since the 1980s — rallied family members, some of whom

lived and worked at the camp, on walkie-talkies to "assess the situation" soon after the alert went out, said Jeff Carr, the family's spokesman. At 2:30 a.m., when rain was falling hard and fast, Eastland decided to begin evacuating campers, Carr said.

Richard Eastland Jr., Dick Eastland's son, said in a brief interview with The Washington Post last week that "the warning came fast." The camp had previously been under a flood watch that leadership was aware of, Eastland Jr. said. The National Weather Service's more urgent alert at 1:14 a.m. had warned of "life threatening flash flooding" in Kerr County, where Camp Mystic is in a flood zone. The alert did not include an evacua-

The situation dissolved into chaos, then tragedy, as the floodwaters rose

tion order. The federal agency does not have the authority to issue evacuation orders, a power that typically falls to local governments.

The statements from the family are the first indications that leaders at Camp Mystic — which has spotty cell service and a policy that limits the use of cellphones — received a warning about the flood before it devastated its 725-acre campus, killing 27 counselors and campers.

Dick Eastland died trying to rescue some of the youngest girls. Carr said that before making further comment, the surviving Eastland family members were gathering Sunday "really for the first time" to share experiences and knowledge of what happened that morning. "It will be important to go through this process and avoid sharing information on a piecemeal basis," he said.

While Camp Mystic was not the only camp in the area to delay its evacuation, a Post examination found that many of the elements that made it special for

SEE EVACUATION ON A8

Abbott and FEMA: The governor's shifting rhetoric on the agency. **A6**

Documents show CIA had connection with JFK's assassin

BY TOM JACKMAN

For more than 60 years, the CIA claimed it had little or no knowledge of Lee Harvey Oswald's activities before the assassination of President John F. Kennedy in November 1963. That wasn't true, new documents unearthed by a House task force

prove. The revelation raises further questions about the agency's awareness of — or involvement in — the plot to murder the president.

The documents confirm that George Joannides, a CIA officer based in Miami in 1963, was helping finance and oversee a group of Cuban students opposed

to the ascension of Fidel Castro. Joannides had a covert assignment to manage anti-Castro propaganda and disrupt pro-Castro groups, even as the CIA was prohibited from domestic spying.

The CIA-backed group known as DRE was aware of Oswald as he publicly promoted a pro-Castro policy for the U.S., and its

members physically clashed with him three months before the assassination. And then, a DRE member said, Oswald approached them and offered his help, possibly to work as a mole within his pro-Castro group, the Fair Play for Cuba Committee.

The CIA had long denied any involvement with the Cuban

group, or any awareness of Oswald's pro-Cuba advocacy. After the most recent release of documents, the agency did not respond to a request for comment.

The House Oversight Committee created a task force on "federal secrets" to revisit the executive orders by President Donald

SEE OSWALD ON A4

A rural clinic's closure is a test for Trump's cuts

Executives blame Medicaid reductions in the new tax bill. Many in town aren't buying it.

BY HANNAH KNOWLES

CURTIS, NEB. — The only health clinic here is shutting down, and the hospital CEO has blamed Medicaid cuts in President Donald Trump's signature legislation. But residents of Curtis — a one-stoplight town in deep-red farm country — aren't buying that explanation.

"Anyone who's saying that Medicaid cuts is why they're closing is a liar," April Roberts said as she oversaw lunch at the Curtis Area Senior Center.

The retirees trickling in for fried chicken and soft-serve ice cream will be hit hardest when

the clinic closes this fall, Roberts fears. Seniors who sometimes go in multiple times a month to have blood drawn will have to drive 40 miles to the next nearest health center. Sick people, she worries, will put off checkups and get sicker.

Arriving for lunch, retired Navy veteran Jim Christensen said he'd read an op-ed that "tried to blame everything on Trump."

"Horse feathers," he said, dismissing the idea.

Curtis has become an early test case of the politics of Trump's agenda in rural America, where voters vulnerable to Medicaid

SEE CLINIC ON A5



REBECCA S. GRATZ/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

April Roberts, director of the Curtis Area Senior Center in Curtis, Nebraska, population 806.

Trump shores up Kyiv in war

THREATENS RUSSIA WITH TARIFFS

U.S. arms to Ukraine will flow through Europeans

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND EMILY DAVIES

Weighing in on Kyiv's side of its war with Russia more forcefully than at any time since he reclaimed the White House, President Donald Trump said Monday that he would help Ukraine obtain advanced U.S.-made weaponry and threatened tariffs against Moscow and its trading partners if the war is still raging in 50 days.

The announcements came after Trump repeatedly expressed frustration with Russian President Vladimir Putin's continued bombardment of Ukraine.

Until Monday, Trump had largely held back from opening the U.S. arsenal for Ukraine, avoiding putting his fingerprint on a conflict that he often said was "Biden's war."

Although he said again Monday that "this is not Trump's war," the plans he unveiled amounted to a significant U.S. effort to bolster Ukraine's military and impose tough economic consequences on Russia if Putin doesn't soon halt the conflict. The efforts would build on — and go beyond — those

SEE UKRAINE ON A11

U.S. firm challenges global aid rule book

Established principles set aside in bid to get food to war-torn places for profit

BY KATHARINE HOURELD

Grace was scared and hungry. The 30-year-old had fled the South Sudanese town of Nasir in March after a deadly raid on a military garrison and retaliatory bombings. As her house burned, Grace said, she grabbed her three children and ran.

She had spent her savings on a bag of sorghum, but the little ones were still hungry. Last month, Grace heard that free food was being given out in Nasir — fat white bags of beans and flour emblazoned with the South Sudanese flag. On June 16, the bags tumbled from a light-colored plane that flew low over the caramel river and green fields near her home.

But Grace refused to go back. She didn't know the airdrops were being coordinated by a U.S. company, Fogbow, that had been hired by officials in South Sudan's isolated regime. But she knew the food was coming from the same government that had bombed her town — and she feared it was a scheme to lure civilians like her back under its control and bolster its own legitimacy with their return.

SEE AID ON A20

IN THE NEWS

Sectarian clashes Israeli jets struck Syrian forces seeking to quell violence between the Druze minority and Bedouin clans. **A11**

Metrobus changes Despite hiccups, the system's first overhaul in 50 years has gone "even better than expected," Metro chief Randy Clarke said. **B13**

THE NATION
A new policy deems those who enter the U.S. illegally ineligible for bond hearings. **A6**
Andrew Cuomo will run as an independent as he continues his bid for New York mayor. **A7**

THE WORLD
After high school years shaped by war, many Israeli teens feel ready for the draft. **A10**
Budapest police will not arrest participants in last month's Pride parade in the city. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
Tech billionaire Marc Andreessen said in a private chat that universities will "pay the price" for diversity efforts. **A14**
Jury selection began in a federal trial over whether Tesla's driver-assistance technology was to blame for a fatal 2019 crash. **A16**

STYLE
Milkmaid dresses and floral patterns are slowly becoming part of the conservative "it" girl uniform. **B1**
SPORTS
James Wood launched 16 homers deep into the Atlanta night, but the Nats star fell short at the Home Run Derby. **B7**

THE REGION
Maryland is looking to ease its shortage of teachers by funding training and certification for former federal workers. **B13**
The D.C. Council advanced a budget that softens some of the cuts proposed by Mayor Muriel E. Bowser. **B13**

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54278

